ABOUT THIS PIECE

Case study: Alex (intellectual disability)

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WHAT IT IS

A case study analysis (Chapter 11) of Alex, an upper-elementary student with a mild to moderate intellectual disability, using the self-determined learning model of instruction.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How instruction builds the student's own goal-setting.

Case study analysis: Alex (intellectual disability)

Chapter 11: Intellectual disability · Katherine Conklin

Student: Alex **Grade:** Upper elementary **Classification:** Intellectual disability (mild to moderate)

Student overview

Alex is a student with a mild to moderate intellectual disability who receives instruction in both general education and special education environments. He is friendly and eager to participate in classroom routines and enjoys hands-on activities, especially when they are connected to real-world contexts.

His educational team has created a schedule that balances academic, functional, and social learning. His IEP is guided by the self-determined learning model of instruction, empowering Alex to identify goals and participate actively in planning how to meet them.

Academic and behavioral needs

Academic needs

- Difficulty reading traditional grade-level texts, but recognizes and reads environmental print (exit signs, store logos)
- Needs direct instruction in functional math such as identifying prices, using number lines, and counting change
- Requires visual supports and real-world applications to understand abstract concepts

Adaptive behavior needs

- Needs help with daily routines, such as transitioning between activities and managing time independently
- Benefits from consistent visual schedules and prompts to increase independence
- Requires reinforcement to maintain and generalize learned skills across settings

Social and communication needs

- Communicates effectively with familiar adults and peers, though may need cues to stay on topic or use age-appropriate language
- Enjoys peer interactions and works best in structured settings with predictable routines

Priority areas for intervention

- Functional reading and math skills
- Increased independence in school routines and tasks
- Goal setting and choice making (self-determination)

Measurable objectives

Academic goal: Alex will use a visual menu to choose and write down items for a class snack shopping list with 80% accuracy, 4 out of 5 opportunities.

Adaptive goal: Alex will follow a three-step routine (pack up, clean desk, check schedule) independently with 90% accuracy across two consecutive weeks.

Self-determination goal: Alex will use a student-friendly goal sheet to select one weekly classroom goal and reflect on his progress using a visual rating scale.

Evidence-based strategies

- **Embedded instruction:** academic skills are taught within functional routines (math during snack shopping, reading signs in the hallway)
- **Self-determined learning model of instruction:** Alex is supported in setting goals, creating a plan, and evaluating his own learning
- **Visual schedules and task cards:** used throughout the day to support transitions and multi-step tasks
- **Community-based instruction:** Alex practices life skills in school and nearby community locations

Inclusion and transition planning

Alex's IEP team prioritizes inclusion in the general education classroom where appropriate, especially during specials, homeroom routines, and hands-on science. Academic instruction focuses on real-life applications through collaboration between his general and special education teachers.

His transition planning includes early exposure to vocational preparation, self-care goals, and daily living activities, preparing him for long-term success beyond school. His case highlights the importance of a functional curriculum that still encourages high expectations and student voice.

Alex is a real example described in Exceptional Lives (Turnbull et al., 2019), where his educational team successfully integrates instructional strategies like embedded instruction, community-based experiences, and self-determined learning. His progress shows how thoughtful, inclusive planning can empower students with intellectual disabilities to thrive in school and build independence.